

Reality Drift

Canonical Concept Paper

A. Jacobs | Reality Drift Framework | 2023–2026

Canonical Definition

Reality Drift is the condition in which a system remains operational and internally coherent while the representations guiding it progressively lose corrective contact with the reality they are meant to track, describe, or govern.

It is an accumulating loss of alignment rather than a single mistake or sudden breakdown. Metrics, models, categories, procedures, narratives, and interfaces can continue organizing action even as they become less answerable to the conditions they represent.

Optimization, abstraction, mediation, and scale are common pathways into drift. None is sufficient by itself. The defining pattern is operational continuity combined with weakening reality-based correction.

What Makes It Distinct

Reality Drift builds on earlier analyses of alienation, hyperreality, and media mediation. Those frameworks often describe distortion, simulation, or dislocation as cultural or philosophical conditions.

Reality Drift instead describes an operational pattern in which systems continue to function and perform while gradually diverging from the real-world conditions they were designed to reflect. Outputs remain coherent and performance metrics may improve, yet alignment weakens over time.

The phenomenon is structural, capturing how optimization can preserve surface functionality while eroding reference to underlying reality.

Mechanism

Modern systems optimize for measurable indicators such as engagement, efficiency, compliance, and growth.

Paradoxically, this optimization can increase divergence from underlying purpose:

- Metrics begin to substitute for meaning.
- Representation replaces direct feedback.
- Processes continue even as grounding weakens.

As abstraction and scale increase, decisions rely more heavily on indicators, dashboards, and models. Recursive mediation through algorithms and institutional layers compresses nuance at each stage. The result is cumulative misalignment without visible system failure.

How It Shows Up

Reality Drift is recognizable across modern life:

- Political discourse feels scripted regardless of substance.
- Cultural products feel iterative rather than original.
- News cycles repeat patterns until events blur together.
- Organizational dashboards simulate productivity while obscuring value.
- Individuals adapt behavior to algorithmic incentives rather than lived priorities.

Nothing visibly breaks. The system continues functioning, but the connection to lived reality weakens.

Cross-Domain Effects

Reality Drift extends across multiple domains.

Psychology / Neuroscience: Individuals experience disorientation when optimized signals no longer align with perception and lived context.

AI / Technology: Systems produce fluent, coherent outputs that remain internally consistent while drifting from user intent or real-world grounding.

Education: Learning environments prioritize measurable outputs over deep understanding.

Work / Organizations: Performance indicators substitute for value creation, obscuring actual outcomes.

Culture / Media: Engagement optimization amplifies performance and narrative over reference and substance.

Theoretical Context

Reality Drift extends analyses of alienation and mediation into the era of algorithmic optimization. It sits adjacent to:

- Theories of alienation
- Hyperreality and simulation
- Media ecology and technological mediation

This framework centers on sustained optimization and mediation operating without adequate contextual feedback. The concern is how systems can maintain coherence and performance while alignment with real-world conditions progressively weakens.

Practical Mitigations

Because Reality Drift is structural, mitigation requires systemic and cultural responses:

- Designing systems that preserve contextual feedback
- Reducing incentive structures that reward surface coherence over substance
- Restoring shared temporal and social rhythms
- Encouraging grounded, imperfect forms of expression
- Creating environments with reduced metric visibility

These interventions aim to rebalance efficiency with contextual grounding.

In One Sentence

Reality Drift is the progressive loss of corrective contact between a system's representations and the real-world conditions they are meant to track, even while the system remains functional and internally coherent.